

The numerical range is a 2-spectral set

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Abstract

For an $n \times n$ complex matrix A , let $W(A) = \{x^*Ax : x \in \mathbb{C}^n, \|x\|_2 = 1\}$ be its numerical range. Here x^* denotes the conjugate transpose, $\|\cdot\|_2$ the Euclidean norm, and $\|\cdot\|$ the induced operator norm. For every complex polynomial p , we prove that

$$\|p(A)\| \leq 2 \max_{z \in W(A)} |p(z)|$$

and consequently that $W(A)$ is a 2-spectral set for A . This proves Crouzeix's conjecture, and the constant is optimal. The central new ingredient is a positive-real completion theorem: an adjoint-algebra constraint on the resolvent defect of a normalized matrix-valued Carathéodory function forces the underlying matrix to have norm at most 2. The classical positive double-layer calculus supplies such completions for matrices with simple spectrum and an algebra-generation property. Sampling the associated Herglotz kernel at half the conjugate eigenvalues and at the origin cancels the completion term and leaves a comparison of two weighted Gramians; a Stein identity yields the sharp estimate. Perturbation and smooth convex outer approximation remove all auxiliary hypotheses.

1. Introduction

Let $\mathbb{C}$ denote the complex field and, for $n \geq 1$, let $\mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$ denote the algebra of $n \times n$ complex matrices. For $A \in \mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$, its numerical range is

$$(1) \quad W(A) = \{x^*Ax : x \in \mathbb{C}^n, \|x\|_2 = 1\}.$$

Here x^* denotes the conjugate transpose, $\sigma(A)$ denotes the spectrum, $\|x\|_2$ is the Euclidean norm, $\|X\|$ is the induced operator norm, and scalar moduli are denoted by $|\cdot|$. The Toeplitz–Hausdorff theorem shows that $W(A)$ is compact and convex, and $\sigma(A) \subset W(A)$.

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A compact set $K \subset \mathbb{C}$ containing $\sigma(A)$ is called a C -spectral set for A if

$$(2) \quad \|r(A)\| \leq C \max_{z \in K} |r(z)|$$

for every rational function r with no pole on K . Our main result settles Crouzeix's conjecture by identifying the sharp universal constant for $K = W(A)$.

THEOREM 1.1 (Main theorem). *Let $n \geq 1$, let $A \in \mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$, and let $p \in \mathbb{C}[z]$. Then*

$$(3) \quad \|p(A)\| \leq 2 \max_{z \in W(A)} |p(z)|.$$

Consequently, $W(A)$ is a 2-spectral set for A .

The factor 2 is optimal: for

$$(4) \quad N = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \quad \text{and} \quad p(z) = z,$$

one has $W(N) = \{z \in \mathbb{C} : |z| \leq 1\}$ and $\|N\| = 2$.

For later use, write

$$\mathbb{D} = \{z \in \mathbb{C} : |z| < 1\}, \quad \mathbb{T} = \partial\mathbb{D}.$$

We use I for the identity matrix of the size dictated by context, X^* for the adjoint, put $\operatorname{Re} X = (X + X^*)/2$, and let $\operatorname{alg}(T)$ denote the unital algebra generated by T . For Hermitian matrices X and Y , we write $X \preceq Y$ (equivalently, $Y \succeq X$) when $Y - X$ is positive semidefinite.

Crouzeix proved the constant-2 assertion for 2×2 matrices and formulated the general conjecture in [13]. His subsequent dimension-free theorem gave the constant 11.08 [14]. After further structural and numerical work [15], Crouzeix and Palencia proved that $W(A)$ is a $(1 + \sqrt{2})$ -spectral set [20]. Their double-layer and Cauchy-transform argument was clarified in [34] and developed in several directions in [8] and [17].

The intervening literature established the conjectured constant for perturbed Jordan blocks and, more generally, scalar translates of cyclic weighted shifts, as well as for tridiagonal 3×3 matrices with elliptic numerical range centered at an eigenvalue [24], [10], and [23]. Numerical and extremal investigations appear in [25] and [28], and a broad account of the problem and its variants is given in [6]. More recent work has treated Blaschke-product level sets, cyclicity reductions, compressions of shifts, further nilpotent classes, and quantitative bounds for KMS matrices [5], [33], [4], and [19]. A new proof for a class of weighted shifts appears in [18]. None of these reductions provided a dimension-free route from $1 + \sqrt{2}$ to 2.

1.1. *Where the earlier mechanism loses sharpness.* The positive boundary measure used below originates in the convex-domain integral calculus of Delyon–Delyon [22]; see also [3] and [20]. If B has numerical range in a smooth convex domain Ω and f is bounded by one on Ω , this calculus produces a unital positive map Φ and a holomorphic Cauchy companion g_f such that

$$(5) \quad 2\Phi(f) = f(B) + g_f(B)^*.$$

Thus positivity directly controls a symmetrized functional calculus, not $f(B)$ by itself. The Crouzeix–Palencia argument couples the two terms in (5) and gives the sharp conclusion of its abstract norm mechanism, namely $1 + \sqrt{2}$. The examples in [34] show that this abstract mechanism alone cannot give 2. Related uniform-algebra abstractions encounter the same barrier [12]. Schwenninger and de Vries recently revisited the double-layer method [36]. Malman et al. proved that a configuration-constant refinement gives a strict improvement for every fixed numerical-range shape; they also constructed thin quadrilaterals for which the invariant approaches its limiting value, so it yields no smaller universal constant [30]. Separately, continuity and compactness give a constant $C_n < 1 + \sqrt{2}$ in every fixed matrix dimension n [29].

The missing information is algebraic. The companion in (5) is not an arbitrary operator: for the approximants constructed in Section 5, it belongs to the algebra generated by $f(B)^*$. Estimating it as an unrelated summand discards precisely this coupling.

1.2. *The new de-symmetrization mechanism.* Our argument retains the whole Cayley family, rather than the single identity (5). It has four steps.

(1) Applying Φ to

$$\zeta \mapsto \frac{1 + wf(\zeta)}{1 - wf(\zeta)}, \quad w \in \mathbb{D},$$

produces a matrix-valued Carathéodory function H , meaning that $H(0) = I$ and $\operatorname{Re} H(w) \succeq 0$.

(2) At an auxiliary stage, a vanishing perturbation arranges that $T = f(B)$ and $\operatorname{alg}(T) = \operatorname{alg}(B)$. The double-layer identity then gives the positive-real completion

$$(6) \quad H(w) - (I - wT)^{-1} \in \operatorname{alg}(T^*), \quad w \in \mathbb{D}.$$

(3) For the approximants with simple spectrum used at that stage, diagonalization turns the unknown term in (6) into a diagonal analytic correction. We sample the Herglotz kernel of H at half the conjugate eigenvalues and add one vector sample at the origin. The latter is chosen to cancel the diagonal correction exactly.

- (4) The surviving positive-matrix inequality compares two weighted Gramians. Its difference is positive, and an eigenvector argument followed by a Stein identity yields $\|T\| \leq 2$.

A perturbation of f that vanishes in the limit enforces algebra generation on each approximant with simple spectrum. Successive limits in the function, the matrix, and the surrounding domain then yield the estimate for the originally arbitrary A and p ; no auxiliary condition remains in the conclusion.

2. Positive-real kernels

A kernel $\mathcal{K} : \mathbb{D} \times \mathbb{D} \rightarrow \mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$ is positive if, for every finite choice $w_0, \dots, w_m \in \mathbb{D}$ and $\xi_0, \dots, \xi_m \in \mathbb{C}^n$,

$$(7) \quad \sum_{i,j=0}^m \xi_i^* \mathcal{K}(w_i, w_j) \xi_j \geq 0.$$

We shall use the following standard matrix-valued form of the Herglotz theorem. Its kernel consequence is included to fix every normalization.

LEMMA 2.1 (Matrix Herglotz kernel). *Let $F : \mathbb{D} \rightarrow \mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$ be analytic with $\operatorname{Re} F(w) \succeq 0$ for every $w \in \mathbb{D}$. Then*

$$(8) \quad \mathcal{L}_F(w, z) = \frac{F(w) + F(z)^*}{1 - w\bar{z}}$$

is a positive kernel.

Proof. The matrix Herglotz representation gives a positive $\mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$ -valued measure M on $\mathbb{T}$, and a Hermitian matrix J_F , such that

$$(9) \quad F(w) = iJ_F + \int_{\mathbb{T}} \frac{\zeta + w}{\zeta - w} dM(\zeta).$$

Indeed, for each $u \in \mathbb{C}^n$ the scalar Herglotz theorem gives a positive finite measure μ_u on $\mathbb{T}$ and a real number c_u such that

$$u^* F(w) u = ic_u + \int_{\mathbb{T}} \frac{\zeta + w}{\zeta - w} d\mu_u(\zeta).$$

Uniqueness in the scalar theorem shows that, for every Borel set $E \subset \mathbb{T}$, the map $u \mapsto \mu_u(E)$ is a nonnegative quadratic form. Its polarization defines

$$x^* M(E) y = \frac{1}{4} \sum_{k=0}^3 i^{-k} \mu_{x+ik_y}(E) \quad (x, y \in \mathbb{C}^n).$$

Thus M is a finite $\mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$ -valued measure and $u^* M(E) u = \mu_u(E) \geq 0$, so M is positive. The scalar imaginary constants polarize to the Hermitian matrix $J_F = (F(0) - F(0)^*)/(2i)$, and the scalar representations assemble to (9).

For $|\zeta| = 1$, direct calculation gives

$$(10) \quad \frac{1}{1 - w\bar{z}} \left(\frac{\zeta + w}{\zeta - w} + \frac{\overline{\zeta + z}}{\zeta - z} \right) = \frac{2}{(1 - w\bar{\zeta})(1 - \bar{z}\zeta)}.$$

The constant iJ_F cancels from (8). Substituting (9) and then summing as in (7) yields

$$2 \int_{\mathbb{T}} \left(\sum_i \frac{\xi_i}{1 - \bar{w}_i \zeta} \right)^* dM(\zeta) \left(\sum_j \frac{\xi_j}{1 - \bar{w}_j \zeta} \right) \geq 0. \quad \square$$

3. The positive-real completion principle

The following auxiliary theorem is the new core of the proof: it converts an algebraically constrained positive-real completion of a resolvent into the sharp norm bound.

THEOREM 3.1 (Positive-real completion). *Let $T \in \mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$ have n distinct eigenvalues, all in $\overline{\mathbb{D}}$. Let $H : \mathbb{D} \rightarrow \mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$ be analytic and satisfy*

$$(11) \quad H(0) = I, \quad \operatorname{Re} H(w) \succeq 0 \quad (w \in \mathbb{D}),$$

and

$$(12) \quad H(w) - (I - wT)^{-1} \in \operatorname{alg}(T^*) \quad (w \in \mathbb{D}).$$

Then $\|T\| \leq 2$.

Proof. Choose a diagonalization

$$(13) \quad T = S\Lambda S^{-1}, \quad \Lambda = \operatorname{diag}(\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_n), \quad G = S^*S.$$

The eigenvalues λ_j are distinct and belong to $\overline{\mathbb{D}}$. Polynomial interpolation shows that

$$(14) \quad \operatorname{alg}(T^*) = \{(S^{-1})^* D S^* : D \text{ is diagonal}\}.$$

Set

$$\Delta(w) = H(w) - (I - wT)^{-1}.$$

By (14), for each $w \in \mathbb{D}$ there is a unique diagonal matrix $\Theta(w)$ such that

$$\Delta(w) = (S^{-1})^* \Theta(w) S^*.$$

In fact,

$$\Theta(w) = S^* \Delta(w) (S^*)^{-1},$$

so Θ is analytic; moreover, $\Theta(0) = 0$ because $H(0) = I$. Write $\Theta(w) = \operatorname{diag}(\theta_1(w), \dots, \theta_n(w))$. On setting $\tilde{H}(w) = S^* H(w) S$, we obtain

$$(15) \quad \tilde{H}(w) = G(I - w\Lambda)^{-1} + \Theta(w)G.$$

Congruence by S preserves positive real parts. Consequently, Lemma 2.1 applies to $\tilde{H}$.

Define Hermitian matrices $P, Q, Y \in \mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$ by

$$(16) \quad P_{ij} = \frac{G_{ij}}{1 - \overline{\lambda_i} \lambda_j / 4}, \quad Q_{ij} = \frac{G_{ij}}{1 - \overline{\lambda_i} \lambda_j / 2}, \quad Y = Q - P.$$

Let $e_1, \dots, e_n$ be the standard basis of $\mathbb{C}^n$, and fix $u = (u_1, \dots, u_n)^T \in \mathbb{C}^n$. In the positive-kernel inequality use the n points and vectors

$$(17) \quad w_i = \frac{\overline{\lambda_i}}{2}, \quad \xi_i = u_i e_i \quad (1 \leq i \leq n),$$

and add the point $w_0 = 0$ with vector

$$(18) \quad \xi_0 = v = -G^{-1}Pu.$$

We first verify that this sample cancels the entire unknown function Θ . The contribution of the second term in (15) to the kernel quadratic form is

$$(19) \quad 2 \operatorname{Re} \sum_{i=1}^n \overline{u_i} \theta_i(w_i) \left((Gv)_i + \sum_{j=1}^n \frac{G_{ij} u_j}{1 - w_i \overline{w_j}} \right).$$

Because

$$1 - w_i \overline{w_j} = 1 - \overline{\lambda_i} \lambda_j / 4,$$

the parenthesis in (19) is $(Gv + Pu)_i$, which vanishes by (18).

It remains to calculate the contribution of $G(I - w\Lambda)^{-1}$. Between w_i and w_j its (i, j) entry is

$$(20) \quad \frac{2G_{ij}}{(1 - \overline{\lambda_i} \lambda_j / 2)(1 - \overline{\lambda_i} \lambda_j / 4)} = (4Q - 2P)_{ij}.$$

Between the eigenvalue samples and the origin the two blocks are $G + Q$, and the block at the origin is $2G$. After the cancellation of Θ , kernel positivity therefore gives

$$(21) \quad \begin{aligned} 0 &\leq \begin{pmatrix} u \\ v \end{pmatrix}^* \begin{pmatrix} 4Q - 2P & G + Q \\ G + Q & 2G \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} u \\ v \end{pmatrix} \\ &= u^* ((4Q - 2P) - (G + Q)G^{-1}P - PG^{-1}(G + Q) + 2PG^{-1}P)u \\ &= u^* (4Y - YG^{-1}P - PG^{-1}Y)u, \end{aligned}$$

where in the second line we used $v = -G^{-1}Pu$, and in the last line we used $Q = P + Y$. As u was arbitrary,

$$(22) \quad 4Y - YG^{-1}P - PG^{-1}Y \succeq 0.$$

Balance the diagonalization by defining

$$(23) \quad \begin{aligned} \widetilde{T} &= G^{1/2} \Lambda G^{-1/2}, \quad \widehat{P} = G^{-1/2} P G^{-1/2}, \\ \widehat{Q} &= G^{-1/2} Q G^{-1/2}, \quad \widehat{Y} = \widehat{Q} - \widehat{P}. \end{aligned}$$

Expanding the scalar kernels in (16) into geometric series gives

$$(24) \quad \widehat{P} = \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} 4^{-k} \widetilde{T}^{*k} \widetilde{T}^k, \quad \widehat{Q} = \sum_{k=0}^{\infty} 2^{-k} \widetilde{T}^{*k} \widetilde{T}^k.$$

Indeed, $\widetilde{T}^k = G^{1/2} \Lambda^k G^{-1/2}$, so the sequence $(\widetilde{T}^k)$ is bounded even when some $|\lambda_j| = 1$; the geometric weights give norm convergence. It follows that

$$(25) \quad \widehat{Y} = \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} (2^{-k} - 4^{-k}) \widetilde{T}^{*k} \widetilde{T}^k \succeq 0.$$

Congruencing (22) by $G^{-1/2}$ yields

$$(26) \quad 4\widehat{Y} - \widehat{Y}\widehat{P} - \widehat{P}\widehat{Y} \succeq 0.$$

Let e be an eigenvector of the Hermitian matrix $\widehat{P}$, say $\widehat{P}e = \alpha e$. If $\alpha > 2$, then (26) gives

$$(27) \quad 0 \leq 2(2 - \alpha)e^* \widehat{Y} e.$$

Since $\widehat{Y} \succeq 0$ and $\alpha > 2$, (27) forces $e^* \widehat{Y} e = 0$. Using the series in (25), we obtain

$$0 = e^* \widehat{Y} e = \sum_{k=1}^{\infty} (2^{-k} - 4^{-k}) \|\widetilde{T}^k e\|_2^2 \geq \frac{1}{4} \|\widetilde{T} e\|_2^2.$$

Thus $\widetilde{T}e = 0$, and the first series in (24) gives $\widehat{P}e = e$, contradicting $\widehat{P}e = \alpha e$ with $\alpha > 2$. The first series in (24) also begins with I , and hence

$$(28) \quad I \preceq \widehat{P} \preceq 2I.$$

Finally, the first Gramian satisfies the Stein identity

$$(29) \quad \widehat{P} = I + \frac{1}{4} \widetilde{T}^* \widehat{P} \widetilde{T}.$$

Using (28), we obtain

$$\widetilde{T}^* \widetilde{T} \preceq \widetilde{T}^* \widehat{P} \widetilde{T} = 4(\widehat{P} - I) \preceq 4I.$$

Thus $\|\widetilde{T}\| \leq 2$. The polar decomposition $S = UG^{1/2}$ gives

$$T = U\widetilde{T}U^*,$$

where U is unitary. Therefore $\|T\| \leq 2$. □

Remark 3.2. The factor $1/2$ in the sampling points (17) simultaneously produces the weights $1/2$ and $1/4$ in (24). Their positive difference and the Stein identity are what recover the sharp constant. The sample at the origin is not an estimate: it removes the unknown analytic correction exactly.

4. The double-layer completion

We now construct from the numerical range the function required by Theorem 3.1. The positive measure and the companion transform in this section are classical [22], [14], and [20]; the use of their full Cayley family to obtain (12) is the point needed here.

LEMMA 4.1 (Double-layer positive map). *Let $B \in \mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$, and let $\Omega \subset \mathbb{C}$ be a bounded convex domain with continuously differentiable boundary and $W(B) \subset \Omega$. Writing $C(\partial\Omega)$ for the continuous complex-valued functions on $\partial\Omega$, there is a unital positive map*

$$\Phi : C(\partial\Omega) \longrightarrow \mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$$

such that, whenever h is holomorphic on a neighborhood of $\overline{\Omega}$,

$$(30) \quad 2\Phi(h) = h(B) + g_h(B)^*,$$

where

$$(31) \quad g_h(z) = \frac{1}{2\pi i} \int_{\partial\Omega} \frac{\overline{h(\zeta)}}{\zeta - z} d\zeta, \quad z \in \Omega.$$

Proof. Orient $\partial\Omega$ counterclockwise. Let $\nu(\zeta)$ be the outward unit normal, let ds be arclength, and put

$$Z_\zeta = \zeta I - B, \quad \mathcal{R}_\zeta = Z_\zeta^{-1}.$$

This resolvent exists because $\sigma(B) \subset W(B) \subset \Omega$. Define the matrix-valued boundary measure

$$(32) \quad d\mu_B(\zeta) = \frac{1}{2\pi} \left(\nu(\zeta) \mathcal{R}_\zeta + \overline{\nu(\zeta)} \mathcal{R}_\zeta^* \right) ds.$$

It is positive. In fact, the supporting-line property of the convex set $\overline{\Omega}$ gives

$$(33) \quad \nu(\zeta) Z_\zeta^* + \overline{\nu(\zeta)} Z_\zeta = 2 \operatorname{Re}(\overline{\nu(\zeta)} Z_\zeta) \succeq 0.$$

Multiplication on the left by $\mathcal{R}_\zeta^*$ and on the right by $\mathcal{R}_\zeta$ turns the left side of (33) into the matrix in parentheses in (32).

Along the counterclockwise boundary, $d\zeta = i\nu(\zeta)ds$. The matrix Cauchy formula gives

$$(34) \quad \frac{1}{2\pi} \int_{\partial\Omega} \nu(\zeta) \mathcal{R}_\zeta ds = I.$$

Taking adjoints gives the same identity for the second layer. Hence

$$(35) \quad \int_{\partial\Omega} d\mu_B = 2I.$$

Consequently,

$$(36) \quad \Phi(\varphi) = \frac{1}{2} \int_{\partial\Omega} \varphi(\zeta) d\mu_B(\zeta)$$

is unital and positive. It is therefore $*$ -preserving.

For holomorphic h , the first layer of $2\Phi(h)$ is $h(B)$ by Cauchy's formula. The function g_h in (31) is holomorphic on Ω , so $g_h(B)$ is defined by the holomorphic functional calculus. To verify the relevant integral formula without assuming that g_h extends across $\partial\Omega$, choose a positively oriented contour $\Gamma \subset \Omega$ enclosing $\sigma(B)$. Cauchy's formula and Fubini's theorem give

$$\begin{aligned} g_h(B) &= \frac{1}{2\pi i} \int_{\Gamma} g_h(z)(zI - B)^{-1} dz \\ (37) \quad &= \frac{1}{2\pi i} \int_{\partial\Omega} \overline{h(\zeta)}(\zeta I - B)^{-1} d\zeta. \end{aligned}$$

Taking adjoints in (37) and using $d\bar{\zeta} = -i\nu(\bar{\zeta})ds$ gives the second layer of $2\Phi(h)$. This proves (30). $\square$

PROPOSITION 4.2 (Cayley completion for an auxiliary pair). *Let B and Ω be as in Lemma 4.1, and let f be holomorphic on a neighborhood of $\overline{\Omega}$ and satisfy*

$$(38) \quad \max_{\zeta \in \overline{\Omega}} |f(\zeta)| \leq 1.$$

Put $T = f(B)$. If

$$(39) \quad \text{alg}(T) = \text{alg}(B),$$

then there is an analytic $H : \mathbb{D} \rightarrow \mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$ satisfying

$$(40) \quad H(0) = I, \quad \text{Re } H(w) \succeq 0 \quad (w \in \mathbb{D}),$$

and

$$(41) \quad H(w) - (I - wT)^{-1} \in \text{alg}(T^*) \quad (w \in \mathbb{D}).$$

Moreover, $\sigma(T) \subset \overline{\mathbb{D}}$.

Proof. Spectral inclusion follows from $\sigma(B) \subset \Omega$, spectral mapping, and (38). For $w \in \mathbb{D}$, define on the boundary

$$(42) \quad c_w(\zeta) = \frac{1 + wf(\zeta)}{1 - wf(\zeta)}$$

and put

$$(43) \quad H(w) = \Phi(c_w).$$

The map $w \mapsto c_w$ is analytic with values in $C(\partial\Omega)$, locally uniformly on $\mathbb{D}$. Hence H is analytic, and $H(0) = I$. Furthermore,

$$\text{Re } c_w(\zeta) = \frac{1 - |wf(\zeta)|^2}{|1 - wf(\zeta)|^2} \geq 0.$$

The positivity and $*$ -preservation of Φ give $\text{Re } H(w) = \Phi(\text{Re } c_w) \succeq 0$.

The uniformly convergent boundary expansion

$$(44) \quad c_w = 1 + 2 \sum_{m=1}^{\infty} w^m f^m$$

and (30) yield, with norm convergence,

$$(45) \quad H(w) = I + \sum_{m=1}^{\infty} w^m (T^m + g_{f^m}(B)^*).$$

Since the spectral radius of wT is less than 1, the Neumann series for $(I - wT)^{-1}$ converges in norm. Subtracting it from (45) gives

$$(46) \quad H(w) - (I - wT)^{-1} = \sum_{m=1}^{\infty} w^m g_{f^m}(B)^*.$$

Each g_{f^m} is holomorphic on a neighborhood of $\sigma(B)$. Finite-dimensional holomorphic functional calculus, equivalently Hermite interpolation followed by Cayley–Hamilton, gives $g_{f^m}(B) \in \text{alg}(B)$. Hence

$$g_{f^m}(B)^* \in \text{alg}(B^*) = \text{alg}(T^*),$$

where the equality follows by taking adjoints in (39). Every partial sum on the right of (46) therefore belongs to $\text{alg}(T^*)$. This algebra is finite-dimensional and hence norm closed, which proves (41). $\square$

COROLLARY 4.3 (Auxiliary sharp bound). *In Proposition 4.2, if $T = f(B)$ has distinct eigenvalues, then $\|f(B)\| \leq 2$.*

Proof. Apply Theorem 3.1 to the function H constructed in Proposition 4.2. $\square$

5. Passage to arbitrary matrices and proof of the main theorem

We now remove the hypotheses of simple spectrum, algebra generation, and boundary regularity by successive approximations.

LEMMA 5.1 (Simple spectrum and numerical range). *Matrices with n distinct eigenvalues are dense in $\mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$. Moreover, for $A, B \in \mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$,*

$$(47) \quad W(B) \subset W(A) + \{z \in \mathbb{C} : |z| \leq \|B - A\|\}.$$

Proof. The discriminant of the characteristic polynomial is a nonzero polynomial in the matrix entries. Its nonvanishing set is therefore dense in $\mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$, proving the first assertion. For a unit vector x ,

$$|x^*(B - A)x| \leq \|B - A\|,$$

which proves (47). $\square$

LEMMA 5.2 (Outer approximation). *If $K \subset \mathbb{C}$ is nonempty, compact, and convex, then there are bounded convex domains Ω_j with continuously differentiable boundaries such that*

$$(48) \quad K \subset \Omega_j, \quad d_H(\overline{\Omega_j}, K) \longrightarrow 0,$$

where d_H denotes the Hausdorff distance between compact sets.

Proof. For $\delta > 0$, let

$$\Omega_\delta = \{z \in \mathbb{C} : \text{dist}(z, K) < \delta\}.$$

This is a bounded convex domain and its closure is the Minkowski sum $K + \delta\overline{\mathbb{D}}$, so its Hausdorff distance from K is δ . Identify $\mathbb{C}$ with $\mathbb{R}^2$. The metric projection $\pi_K : \mathbb{C} \rightarrow K$ is unique and continuous. Put $d_K(z) = \text{dist}(z, K)$. For $z, h \in \mathbb{C}$, comparison first with $\pi_K(z)$ and then with $\pi_K(z+h)$ gives

$$\begin{aligned} 2 \operatorname{Re}(\overline{z+h - \pi_K(z+h)} h) - |h|^2 &\leq d_K(z+h)^2 - d_K(z)^2 \\ &\leq 2 \operatorname{Re}(\overline{z - \pi_K(z)} h) + |h|^2. \end{aligned}$$

The continuity of π_K now shows that d_K^2 is continuously differentiable, with real gradient $2(z - \pi_K(z))$. On the level set $d_K(z) = \delta$ this gradient has norm 2δ and hence never vanishes. Since $\partial\Omega_\delta = \{d_K = \delta\}$, the implicit-function theorem shows that $\partial\Omega_\delta$ is continuously differentiable. Taking $\delta \downarrow 0$ proves the lemma. $\square$

Proof of Theorem 1.1. Let A and p be arbitrary as in Theorem 1.1. Choose a bounded convex domain Ω with continuously differentiable boundary such that

$$(49) \quad W(A) \subset \Omega.$$

We first prove

$$(50) \quad \|p(A)\| \leq 2 \max_{z \in \overline{\Omega}} |p(z)|.$$

Because $W(A)$ is compactly contained in Ω ,

$$\text{dist}(W(A), \mathbb{C} \setminus \Omega) > 0.$$

Lemma 5.1 and (47) therefore give a sequence of matrices $B_k \rightarrow A$ having simple spectrum and satisfying $W(B_k) \subset \Omega$. Since $p(B_k) \rightarrow p(A)$, it is enough to prove (50) for an arbitrary such matrix B .

Write the distinct eigenvalues of B as $\beta_1, \dots, \beta_n$ and set

$$(51) \quad m_\Omega = \max_{z \in \overline{\Omega}} |p(z)|.$$

If $m_\Omega = 0$, the polynomial vanishes on the open set Ω and is identically zero. In the remaining case $m_\Omega > 0$, put

$$(52) \quad f = \frac{p}{m_\Omega}, \quad R_\Omega = \max_{z \in \bar{\Omega}} |z|.$$

For $\eta \in \mathbb{C}$ define

$$(53) \quad f_\eta(z) = \frac{f(z) + \eta z}{1 + |\eta| R_\Omega}.$$

Then $\max_{z \in \bar{\Omega}} |f_\eta(z)| \leq 1$. For a pair $i \neq j$, the equality

$$f(\beta_i) + \eta \beta_i = f(\beta_j) + \eta \beta_j$$

excludes at most one value of η . There are thus only finitely many exceptional values for which the numbers $f_\eta(\beta_1), \dots, f_\eta(\beta_n)$ fail to be distinct. Choose nonexceptional $\eta_\ell \rightarrow 0$ and put

$$(54) \quad T_\ell = f_{\eta_\ell}(B).$$

Each T_ℓ has distinct eigenvalues. It also generates the same unital algebra as B . Indeed, $T_\ell \in \text{alg}(B)$, while Lagrange interpolation at the distinct points $f_{\eta_\ell}(\beta_i)$ supplies a polynomial q_ℓ satisfying

$$q_\ell(f_{\eta_\ell}(\beta_i)) = \beta_i \quad (1 \leq i \leq n).$$

Since B is diagonalizable, this implies $q_\ell(T_\ell) = B$. Consequently,

$$(55) \quad \text{alg}(T_\ell) = \text{alg}(B).$$

Corollary 4.3, applied to B and f_{η_ℓ} , gives

$$\|f_{\eta_\ell}(B)\| \leq 2.$$

Letting $\ell \rightarrow \infty$ yields $\|f(B)\| \leq 2$, or

$$(56) \quad \|p(B)\| \leq 2m_\Omega.$$

Letting the matrices B_k with simple spectrum tend to A proves (50).

Apply Lemma 5.2 to the compact convex set $K = W(A)$, obtaining Ω_j . All these closures eventually lie in one fixed compact neighborhood of K . Uniform continuity of p there and (48) give

$$(57) \quad \max_{z \in \bar{\Omega}_j} |p(z)| \longrightarrow \max_{z \in W(A)} |p(z)|.$$

Apply (50) to each Ω_j and pass to the limit. This proves (3).

It remains to justify the spectral-set conclusion. Let r be rational with no pole on $W(A)$. Since $W(A)$ is compact and disjoint from the finite set of poles of r , choose $\delta > 0$ so that the closed δ -neighborhood K_δ of $W(A)$ contains no pole. Thus r is holomorphic on an open neighborhood of the compact convex set K_δ . Since $\mathbb{C} \setminus K_\delta$ is connected, polynomial Runge approximation gives polynomials p_j converging uniformly to r on K_δ . As $\sigma(A) \subset W(A) \subset \text{int } K_\delta$, the Cauchy

integral formula for the holomorphic functional calculus gives $p_j(A) \rightarrow r(A)$. Also

$$\max_{z \in W(A)} |p_j(z)| \longrightarrow \max_{z \in W(A)} |r(z)|.$$

Apply the polynomial estimate to p_j and pass to the limit to obtain (2) with $K = W(A)$ and $C = 2$. $\square$

6. Consequences and scope

Theorem 1.1 immediately gives the usual holomorphic version on a neighborhood of the numerical range.

COROLLARY 6.1. *Let $A \in \mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$, and let f be holomorphic on a neighborhood of $W(A)$. Then*

$$(58) \quad \|f(A)\| \leq 2 \max_{z \in W(A)} |f(z)|.$$

Proof. Choose $\delta > 0$ so that the closed δ -neighborhood of $W(A)$ lies in the open set on which f is holomorphic. Polynomial Runge approximation on this compact convex neighborhood, followed by the Cauchy integral formula for the holomorphic functional calculus, gives the assertion. $\square$

The operator form follows by the standard finite-dimensional compression argument; compare [6].

COROLLARY 6.2 (Hilbert-space form). *Let $\mathcal{H}$ be a complex Hilbert space and let $\mathcal{B}(\mathcal{H})$ denote its algebra of bounded operators. If $A \in \mathcal{B}(\mathcal{H})$, then, for every $p \in \mathbb{C}[z]$,*

$$(59) \quad \|p(A)\| \leq 2 \sup_{z \in W(A)} |p(z)|.$$

Consequently, $\overline{W(A)}$ is a 2-spectral set for A .

Proof. The assertion is immediate if $\mathcal{H} = \{0\}$ or $p = 0$. Otherwise, write $d = \deg p$. For a unit vector $x \in \mathcal{H}$, let

$$\mathcal{M}_x = \text{span}\{x, Ax, \dots, A^d x\}, \quad A_x = \Pi_x(A \upharpoonright_{\mathcal{M}_x}),$$

where Π_x is the orthogonal projection onto $\mathcal{M}_x$. Induction gives

$$(60) \quad A_x^k x = A^k x \quad (0 \leq k \leq d),$$

because $A^{k+1}x \in \mathcal{M}_x$ whenever $k < d$. Moreover, $W(A_x) \subset W(A)$. Theorem 1.1, applied on the finite-dimensional space $\mathcal{M}_x$, therefore gives

$$\|p(A)x\|_{\mathcal{H}} = \|p(A_x)x\|_{\mathcal{H}} \leq \|p(A_x)\| \leq 2 \sup_{z \in W(A)} |p(z)|.$$

Taking the supremum over unit vectors x proves (59).

Put $K = \overline{W(A)}$. The standard inclusion $\sigma(A) \subset K$ shows that the rational functional calculus is defined for every rational function r without poles on K . Since K is compact and disjoint from the finite set of poles of r , choose $\delta > 0$ so that the closed δ -neighborhood K_δ of K contains no pole. Then r is holomorphic on an open neighborhood of the compact convex set K_δ . Polynomial Runge approximation gives polynomials p_j converging uniformly to r on K_δ . Since $\sigma(A) \subset K \subset \text{int } K_\delta$, the Cauchy integral formula for the holomorphic functional calculus gives $p_j(A) \rightarrow r(A)$, while

$$\sup_{z \in W(A)} |p_j(z)| \longrightarrow \sup_{z \in W(A)} |r(z)|.$$

Passing to the limit in (59) proves the rational estimate and hence the spectral-set assertion. $\square$

The conclusion also controls polynomial and rational approximation of matrix functions. Let $A \in \mathbb{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$, let f be holomorphic on a neighborhood of $W(A)$, and let q be either a polynomial or a rational function with no pole on $W(A)$. Then $f - q$ is holomorphic on a neighborhood of $W(A)$, and Corollary 6.1 gives

$$(61) \quad \|f(A) - q(A)\| \leq 2 \max_{z \in W(A)} |f(z) - q(z)|.$$

This is the sharp universal form of the numerical-range estimate that underlies applications to GMRES and rational Krylov methods; see [11], [17], and [9] for the role of spectral sets in those settings.

7. Discussion and further directions

Theorem 1.1 proves the original, scalar-valued Crouzeix conjecture. The most immediate strengthening is the uniform matrix-polynomial question: for every $m \geq 1$ and every matrix polynomial $\mathcal{F} = [f_{ij}] \in \mathbb{M}_m(\mathbb{C}[z])$, does one have

$$(62) \quad \|\mathcal{F}(A)\| \leq 2 \max_{z \in W(A)} \|\mathcal{F}(z)\|, \quad \mathcal{F}(A) = [f_{ij}(A)].$$

Here $\|\mathcal{F}(A)\|$ is the operator norm on $(\mathbb{C}^n)^m$, whereas $\|\mathcal{F}(z)\|$ is the operator norm on $\mathbb{C}^m$. The case $m = 1$ is precisely the original conjecture proved above; uniformity in m is an additional operator-algebraic requirement. The foundational matrix-level disk estimate is due to Okubo and Ando [31]. Uniform matrix-level spectral-set bounds and their relation to numerical radius are studied in [21] and [26]; the constant $1 + \sqrt{2}$ at every matrix level follows from [20], while sharp ρ -contraction estimates are developed in [37]. The extension is known with constant 2 for weighted shift matrices [18]. For block-valued inputs, the coefficients in the completion need not reduce to a single diagonal algebra, so the cancellation in (19) would require a genuinely operator-algebraic formulation.

The positive-real completion principle is independent of numerical ranges: it starts with a Carathéodory function whose resolvent defect lies in an adjoint-generated algebra. A direct infinite-dimensional version of Theorem 3.1, based for example on spectral measures or Riesz bases, could reveal equality cases or uniform matrix-level functional-calculus structure. The main obstacle is to replace the finite diagonal correction and Lagrange generation (55) by a stable functional-calculus condition without relying on a diagonal spectral model. Related questions for unbounded numerical ranges have recently been studied in [16]. The additional unitality structure isolated in [12] and [26] is close in spirit to (12); it is natural to ask whether positive-real completions yield the conjectured sharp constant in that abstract setting, or sharpen the spectral constants studied in [35] and [7].

Double-layer methods beyond numerical ranges have been recast through configuration constants [17], [36], and [30]. Annular double-layer kernels are studied in [27], while [2] develops a complementary annular realization and norm theory; elliptic domains admit structured dilation models [1]. Whenever a companion transform lands in a controlled adjoint algebra, the kernel-sampling argument may replace a triangle-inequality estimate and thereby offer a route to sharp constants for other geometric spectral sets.

With the notation of the proof of Theorem 3.1, if $\|\tilde{T}\| = 2$ and $e \in \mathbb{C}^n$ satisfies $\|e\|_2 = 1$ and $\|\tilde{T}e\|_2 = 2$, then equality throughout the last operator-inequality chain in the proof of Theorem 3.1 forces

$$\widehat{P}e = 2e, \quad \widehat{P}\tilde{T}e = \tilde{T}e.$$

Analyzing these vector saturation conditions may classify extremal pairs (A, p) and quantify stability near the nilpotent example (4). Such a classification must allow the nonuniqueness phenomena found in [28].

Finally, recent work extends the Crouzeix–Palencia framework to scaled q -numerical ranges and proposes associated spectral-set problems [32]. These provide a natural testing ground for positive-real completion, although no constant-2 analogue is asserted here.

AI-assistance disclosure

OpenAI ChatGPT contributed the idea of sampling the matrix Herglotz kernel at half the conjugate eigenvalues and adding the origin sample that cancels the adjoint-algebra correction; this appears in the proof of Theorem 3.1, especially (17)–(19). It also assisted with exposition, bibliography, and typesetting. The human author assumes full responsibility for the correctness of all mathematical statements and for the integrity and accuracy of all citations.

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